UNIVERSITY OF ENGINEERING AND TECHNOLOGY, LAHORE.

Course: Psychology (HU-214) Course Instructor: Sehar Farooq

Week: 1-2

Topic: Introduction to Psychology

a. What is Psychology?

The word psychology is a combination of two Greek words, ***"psyche"*** and ***"logos".*** Psyche means soul, mind, or self, and logos means knowledge or study. That makes psychology the study of the mind (thoughts and feelings) and behavior (what we do). It is also described using terms such as soul, mind, or consciousness.

b. History of psychology

Being human means being curious about ourselves and the world around us. Greek naturalist and philosopher Aristotle theorized about learning and memory, motivation and emotion, perception and personality. Philosophers' thinking about thinking continued until the birth of psychology as we know it. In 1879, in a small, third-floor room at Germany's University of Leipzig, a laboratory was established under the supervision of Professor Wilhelm Wundt. From then on, psychology emerged as a science that consisted of ample evidence of observation and experimentation. Stated below is a brief history of psychology.

Table2.1. Timeline of Psychology from Philosophy to Science

Period	Key Figure(s)	Main Idea	Significance
Ancient Philosophy (600 BCE - 400 CE)	Socrates, Plato, Aristotle	Nature of mind, soul, knowledge	First philosophical questions about human behavior and thought
Islamic Golden Age (872-1040 CE)	Al-Farabi, Ibn Sina, Ibn al-Haytham	Perception, memory, emotion, experimentation	Early scientific study of mental processes
Rationalism & Empiricism (1600s	Descartes, Locke	Mind-body dualism vs. learning through experience	Foundation for later psychological theories
Psychophysics (1800s)	Weber, Fechner, Helmholtz	Measuring sensation and perception	Made mental processes scientifically measurable
Birth of Psychology (1879)	Wilhelm Wundt	Experimental study of consciousness	First psychology laboratory established
Structuralism (1890s)	Edward Titchener	Structure of conscious experience	Used introspection to reveal the structure of the human mind.
Functionalism (1890-1910)	William James	Purpose of behavior and mental processes	Explored how mental and behavioral processes function and how they enable the organism to adapt, survive, and flourish
Psychoanalysis (1900s)	Sigmund Freud	Unconscious mind and childhood experiences	Introduced talk therapy and psychoanalytic theory of personality

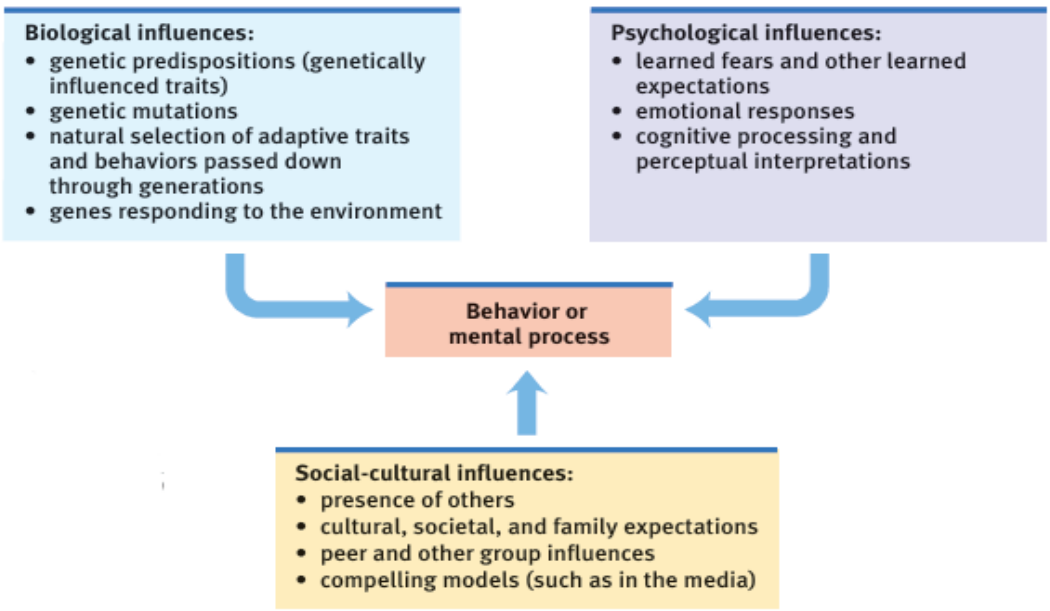
Behaviorism (1913-1950s)	Watson, Skinner	Observable behavior only	Made psychology highly objective and experimental by doing several experiments that measured and observed behavior
Gestalt Psychology (1910s-1940s)	Wertheimer, Köhler, Koffka	Whole is greater than the sum of its parts	Revolutionized understanding of perception
Humanistic Psychology (1950s-1970s)	Rogers, Maslow	Hierarchy of needs, personal growth and self-actualization	Emphasized positive human potential
Cognitive Revolution (1950s-1970s)	Neisser, Miller, Chomsky	Memory, thinking, language	Returned focus to mental processes scientifically
Biological Psychology (1970s-Present)	Neuroscientists	Brain-behavior relationships	Linked psychology with neuroscience
Modern Psychology (2000s-Present)	Interdisciplinary Researchers	Evidence-based and data-driven approaches	Integration of neuroscience, cognitive science, AI, and applied fields

c. Contemporary Psychology

Contemporary psychology refers to the **modern scientific study of behavior and mental processes**, integrating knowledge from psychology, neuroscience, genetics, sociology, anthropology, computer science, and medicine.

Unlike earlier schools (Structuralism, Behaviorism, Psychoanalysis), contemporary psychology does not follow a single perspective. Instead, it uses a **biopsychosocial approach**, considering:

- **Biological factors** (brain, hormones, genetics)
- **Psychological factors** (thoughts, emotions, personality)
- **Social and cultural factors** (family, society, culture)



d. Careers in Psychology

Modern psychology offers diverse career opportunities in mental health, education, business, healthcare, law, sports, and research. Major fields include clinical, counseling, forensic, educational, industrial-organizational, health, and neuropsychology. Contemporary psychologists increasingly work in interdisciplinary areas such as cognitive neuroscience, artificial intelligence, human-computer interaction, and behavioral data analysis, demonstrating the broad application of psychological science in today's world.

Expected Questions

Short Answers

- What is psychology?
- Describe Contemporary psychology.
- Write a few careers in psychology one can pursue.

Long Answers

- Write a brief timeline of psychology, from philosophy to modern science. (Major Five)